Wilting Rose in Arc City

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/33863188.

Rating:	General Audiences
Archive Warning:	No Archive Warnings Apply
Category:	F/F
Fandom:	崩坏3rd | Honkai Impact 3rd (Video Game)
Relationships:	Bianca Astagina | Durandal & Rita Rossweisse, Bianca Astagina | Durandal/Rita Rossweisse
Characters:	Bianca Astagina | Durandal, Rita Rossweisse
Additional Tags:	Fluff, Romantic Fluff, Wounds, care for wounds, Mild Hurt/Comfort, Light Angst, Near Death
Language:	English
Stats:	Published: 2021-09-13 Words: 3,023 Chapters: 1/1

Wilting Rose in Arc City

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Summary

Valkyrie Durandal was called by the Schicksal Overseer, Otto Apocalypse, and deployed on a recovery mission to Arc City; they lost contact with Rita Rossweisse, sent there on a solo mission, and last they had signals of her, it was Carbon Stalker's position, back in the hotel room where she's usually stationed at.
Now it's time for the Captain of the Immortal Blades to go undercover, inspect that place, and find clues about Rita's whereabouts.

Notes

See the end of the work for notes

Valkyrie Durandal walked down the streets of Arc City; it was almost midnight, yet the neon lights illuminated everything brighter than the sun. A few hours earlier, she had been summoned by Overseer Otto and deployed on a recovery mission. Some days ago, he had sent Rita on a solo mission -that much she knew-, but the previous day they lost contact with her and saw fit to send Durandal herself after 24hs without news. In all that time, her coms remained silent, but about ten hours before, they had last registered Carbon Stalker's signal on a hotel room where she was stationed during the mission, a place that worked as a makeshift base for Rita.

—Going undercover isn't my forte but, in a place like this, it's clearly the most sensible plan — Durandal reflected, as she arrived at the hotel. Having planned how to inconspicuously ask about Rita, she entered the place with confidence and walked up to the receptionist. An android greeted her in such a human-like manner that it took Durandal a whole minute to be sure it was actually a machine. —Good night— she finally answered, with a cheerful tone. —I'm looking for a friend lodged here. She hasn't answered lately and we agreed I'll come for her if this happened. She's very polite, tall, and has short brown hair. She *is* staying at this hotel, right?

—Of course. Your friend returned to her room two days ago and hasn't come out since. Not even to have a meal down at the dining area— the android answered honestly, seemingly worried even.

Once it gave her Rita's room number, she thanked it and left. It was a good sign that it didn't try to cover Rita's presence at the hotel, so it couldn't have been their doing if Rita disappeared. However, if it didn't see her leave the room, either she was still there or she had left the place in such a way no one would notice. Worst-case scenario, she had been kidnapped and somehow no one heard a thing.

—Ridiculous. Carbon Stalker wouldn't let anything happen to her without at least sending a distress signal— Durandal thought aloud. She wouldn't admit it, but her worry was slowly building inside her and growing stronger the more she thought about the possibilities. Only once in front of the room's door, the Valkyrie noticed how tense she was. What would she do if Rita wasn't there? Or rather, what would she do if she *was*? The list of reasons for her to be there and still incommunicado was very short. —I shouldn't underestimate her— she told herself, gathering the courage to open the door; a moment later, she stepped inside. Everything was silent, cold, and dark. The place was noticeably tidy, and yet, something seemed off. Durandal carefully stepped in and closed the door without making much noise, and the first thing she noticed was Carbon Stalker, his attention on the door, but running on low energy. —Hey, boy— she whispered, barely touching the mechanical dog's head. He apparently recognized her and turned himself off, deeming his guard unnecessary now that Durandal had arrived. —She should be here if he was guarding the place— she reflected, trying to give herself a reason to thoroughly search the place. Soon enough, she found a door to a second room where someone's body laid on the bed. —Rita?— she recognized almost instantly.

She quickly ran to her side and checked her pulse. Alive. She could once again breathe easily. Whatever happened, she wasn't too late. Carefully, she examined Rita and found a severe

wound on the right side of her torso, still bleeding a little and only stopped by her hand; merely her weight pressing down against the mattress had kept the blood loss at a minimum.

She rushed back to the first room and searched for Rita's supplies, there *had* to be some first-aid equipment to treat the lesion, and after a while, she found enough resources to patch her up before reporting to headquarters. The Valkyrie knew the bleeding was already serious and she couldn't let it continue while she waited for backup, so she carefully picked Rita up, laid her on the clean side of the bed to disinfect the wound, and carefully stopped the bleeding with a gauze. Only then did she call the Overseer to inform her findings, but she couldn't stop looking at Rita. She was extremely pale, sweating, and her expression was still a grimace of pain. Due to the severity of her injuries, and because it would raise suspicions to send a vehicle big enough to safely take Rita back to Headquarters, he resolved to send Durandal some extra supplies to take care of Rita until she was in condition to return. This was also a good opportunity to have Durandal rest for a while, otherwise, she would never stop working.

The next day, around noon, Durandal went down to the reception to receive the supplies sent by the Overseer, from none other than Alvitr. It took her a while to calm the girl down enough to assure her Rita would be fine and that she shouldn't worry, but still, she almost wouldn't have left if it wasn't because Durandal told her she'd trust the Immortal Blades would be fine as long as Alvitr was there.

The next couple of hours, Durandal made use of the supplies received: medical equipment, some clothes, nutritious food, even a medicinal mix of general antidotes. First, she carefully took Rita to the room's bathroom to wash away the blood and sweat, and cool down her body that felt a bit feverish. Second, with the gauze and elastic fabric she received, she could completely cover Rita's torso and finally dressed her in the clothes sent. Third, she changed the bedsheets and took Rita back, set up the medical equipment, and hung a bag of serum, which she then attached to Rita's arm with a needle. Just in case, she decided to give her the antidotes mix; even if Durandal had seen no signs of infection, neither organic nor Honkai energy, it wouldn't do her any harm.

Now, she could only wait. And keep waiting. For days, until Rita had recovered enough to wake up. Meanwhile, she wanted to know, she *needed* to know, what had happened to her, what could have left such gruesome cuts on her torso. Fortunately, she had access to Rita's laptop, and even if Carbon Stalker had run out of energy, she could still access his visual and location records.

Durandal spent the whole night watching all the recordings from Rita's mission with a serving of food from the dining area of the hotel. It wasn't clear when, but she realized only one person could have caused her wound, and she was the last person she fought with.

—We're supposed to be in a truce, why were you two fighting again?— Durandal thought aloud. —It also means I can only hold her accountable in a diplomatic way, if I went after her it would give us more trouble.

Considering her options, she finally reported her findings to headquarters, maybe the Overseer himself could take care of it. However, this meant she was now idle, there was

nothing for her to do at all, which only made her feel restless.

The next day, as Rita was still unconscious, Durandal trained almost half a day, waiting for new orders, hoping something would happen. Yet everything was calm, Headquarters sent no messages or orders, no one came to the room, Rita hadn't moved an inch; the Valkyrie was almost disappointed but didn't dwell much on it, she simply spent the next hours meditating until it was late enough to have dinner.

That night she finally slept. Rita was still unconscious, which worried her, but she was breathing easily, and when changing the gauze she noticed her lesion seemed to be healing nicely. At first, she wasn't sure but in the end, decided to sleep next to her; Durandal wanted to wake up as soon as she did, but if she didn't, at least she wanted her to feel safe.

Only three days later, Rita finally awakened, solely to fall asleep almost immediately. Durandal had just gotten up and thought it was her imagination until she saw her clearly open her eyes and try to speak. But as soon as she was by her side, she fell asleep again. Unsure of when she'd awaken next time, Durandal rushed down to the dining area to get some fresh water and prepared the food she had received from headquarters for her, in case she was hungry despite the serum she'd been getting the past few days, and returned to her side a few minutes before Rita attempted to wake up again.

Durandal took a chair into the room, sat next to her, and kept a bottle of water at hand. Until noon, Rita woke up and fell unconscious several times, but eventually, she was able to remain awake, even if she was too weak to even speak. Durandal talked to her softly, knowing she may not hear every word she said, but trying to be just as comforting as Rita was when taking care of her.

—Please don't push yourself, take your time— Durandal told her when she tried to speak. —You lost too much blood and were unconscious for days. Rest as much as you need— she continued.

Eventually, Rita had regained enough strength to sit back against the wall and even talk, but her throat was sore and it hurt her to speak at first. Durandal removed the needle from her arm, offered her some water to slowly drink, and busied herself putting away all the medical equipment while Rita silently sipped water.

—Thank you— she finally said. Durandal looked back at her a bit surprised. After a short silence, she continued —I never… hoped to survive. A-actually, I was… sure I'd die.

—What?— Durandal asked, so confused she went back to sit next to her. —What are you talking about?

—Usually, I… I can handle these… missions with ease, bu-but this time…—, Rita took a deep breath trying to strengthen her speech. With a smile, she continued —Well, don't worry too much… about what happened, Master Durandal. I simply meant… I'm not used to

getting any help. I-I am expected to finish and clean my own trails; if I… fail, if I get hurt, I'm on my own.

—But, the Overseer sent me because you didn't return twenty-four hours after they last had contact with you.

—I should have been… presumed dead and left.

—What? Why!?— Durandal interrupted, clearly baffled.

Rita looked at her with an expression of both sorrow and endearment. She smiled but never answered.

As if on queue, before Durandal could insist, they received a call from headquarters. The Overseer was already aware of Rita's improvement and wanted to know how she was feeling, but when Durandal offered her to speak with him, she could barely shake her head to refuse, clearly too weak still. Seeing her like that, she realized it would be rude to try and continue their conversation after the call, but she could instead ask the Overseer about it, so she left the room to speak privately.

Hours later, the room was in complete silence. Durandal didn't know if Rita had fallen asleep but she wanted to believe she had, otherwise nothing would stop her from just barging into the room and *begging* her to deny all of what the Overseer had told her.

The phone was still in her hand, she had been in the same position, just seated looking at the ceiling, since the call ended. Durandal had no idea how much time had passed, she hadn't registered all the hours that went on as her mind was too consumed in thoughts.

Was it all true? Was *death* part of Rita's missions in such an impending way that returning was another mission entirely? How could she agree to something like that? And why didn't *she* know before now?

Only when she heard a noise coming from the room were her thoughts interrupted and Durandal finally returned to reality. She walked into the room slowly, realizing Rita was still recovering, and went to her side.

—Master… Durandal…— she began, trying to speak as if she were fine, but her voice betrayed her.

—Don't, please. You haven't fully healed— Durandal interrupted her. —Do you want to eat? Are you hungry?—. Rita nodded with a faint smile as she neared with a bowl of the nutritional food she had been sent days before. However, when Rita tried to reach for it, she simply couldn't hold it. —Leave it to me.

Durandal carefully fed her, she needed time between each bite and couldn't eat much this first time, but the fact that she was hungry was a good thing. Later, she picked her up and took her to the bathroom to wash her and change the bandages.

—Master Durandal… you have… been doing… this…?— Rita began asking, but couldn't finish speaking.

Durandal nodded as she took her back to bed.

—I found you just in time. And I would never let you die just like that.

Out of habit, Durandal went to rest by her side, holding her as she had done the last days, but hesitated a moment. However, Rita comfortably rested her head against her and took a deep breath.

—Thank you—, she whispered, —For taking… care of me.

Durandal smiled and gently hugged her as they both fell asleep.

For another two days, the valkyries followed the same routine: once Rita awakened, Durandal would feed her, then check her bandages, let her rest, wake her up for the next meal, serve her tea so her throat would recover faster, and before going to sleep, she'd help Rita bathe and check her bandages one last time.

Fortunately, the next day Rita was strong enough to get up from bed and sit at the table for breakfast.

—I'm so glad you're recovering so well, Rita— Durandal told her, with genuine happiness, as she brought her breakfast. —I've been so worried… I mean, I already told you, but I was afraid there might be permanent damage— she continued, interrupting herself to clarify the idea.

Rita stifled a giggled and picked up her cup of tea. She carefully took a sip, like considering what she was going to say and how, and after a few moments, looked at Durandal who had sat on her right with her own breakfast, seemingly oblivious of her intention to speak.

—I'd like to thank you, Master Durandal, for taking care of me— Rita began speaking. The woman in front of her looked up as if she had spoken in another language. —All the effort you made to make sure I'd recover…

—I just did what I had to— Durandal interrupted. —I'm confident you would've done the same for me.

Rita looked down and shook her head.

—I don't mean that. What I'm trying to say, Master Durandal, is that I'm grateful for what you did, for having done it— she insisted. Something in Rita's eyes kept Durandal focused on listening to her this time. —I sincerely thought I was going to die, and I… I was afraid. Even if I had accepted my fate, I was still afraid— she admitted. Rita looked directly into Durandal's eyes before continuing —So when I woke up and saw you, Master Durandal, it felt like a blessing I didn't deserve. I shouldn't…

—Rita— she interrupted her again. Durandal didn't hesitate, she rose from her chair and cupped Rita's head, tilting it up slightly to press their foreheads together. —Of course you deserved it. I said I would never let you die like that, and I really mean it— Durandal assures her with a serious tone. She then looks at Rita who seems to be holding back tears. —I'm infinitely glad I arrived on time and that you're now recovering so well.

Her words were almost a whisper as if afraid saying it too loudly would break Rita's currently fragile sense of self-worth. And once she had told her what she meant with words, Durandal couldn't help demonstrating it too. Slowly but surely, she closed the distance and gently kissed Rita on her lips.

Later that day, both valkyries went down to the dining area to have lunch as they waited for their transport to arrive. Everything was ready, all their belongings packed, and now they could just sit back and enjoy the end of their time off.

—Arc City looks so different during the day— Durandal commented as she looked outside through the window. —Have you ever just toured the city?

Rita smiled at the innocence of Durandal's expression and how genuinely interested she seemed, and nodded.

—I have walked around some beautiful sectors of the city. Just like you said, during the day it's a whole new place— she answered. Rita finished her tea and left the cup on the table before reaching out for Durandal's hand. —I suppose next time you should come too so I can show you around, Master Durandal.

The valkyrie held her hand tightly and replied —Gladly, as long as you stop calling me "master".

Rita giggled and a mischievous look overtook her expression.

—Aren't you my superior? Am I not at your service?

Durandal's face got completely red and she stammered as she tried to explain —Well but… I mean, when you say it like that… I mean to say I hope you're less formal with me from now on—. She was looking away, feeling too embarrassed to keep eye contact, but still added — That is… if it meant anything to you.

Rita's grip on her hand tightened, but instead of answering, she stood up, pulled Durandal up with her, and kissed her for a moment.

—It did, of course it did.

That same moment, they noticed a shiny vehicle parking just outside the place and realized it was their transport. Time to head back to work.

End Notes

I won't lie: I cant write better stuff than this, and hadn't this burnt out my head so much, I'd probably polish it a bit more but... meh... it's just fluff...

Hope it's enjoyable though!

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